



△ INTERNAL COURTYARDS

In Gaudí's ingenious design, the entire complex of the Casa Milà was arranged around two large courtyards. The irregularly shaped shaft channeled extra light and ventilation into all of the apartments.

Casa Milà

A stunning example of Modernist architecture, groundbreaking biomorphic design, and Gaudí's last private commission



S. Europe



Located in the heart of Barcelona, the Casa Milà is one of the greatest works of Catalan architect Antoni Gaudí.

It is one of the seven properties designed by him that UNESCO have placed on their World Heritage List owing to their "outstanding creative contribution to the architectural heritage of modern times."

The Casa Milà was commissioned in 1906 by Pere Milà, a wealthy textile industrialist. He and his wife admired another of Gaudí's buildings—the Casa Batlló—and wanted something similar. Unfortunately for them, Gaudí was a visionary genius, not given to repeating his experiments. He

◁ UNDULATING FACADE

The surfaces of Gaudí's buildings convey a sense of movement, undulating like waves. The facade is like a curtain, however, carrying no weight and concealing the solid structure behind.

altered the design during the construction process, creating something very different, and they were unhappy with the result. The reaction of the general public was equally negative, and the building was dubbed *La Pedrera*, or the "stone quarry."

Organic inspiration

The Casa Milà is essentially an apartment block on the corner of two streets. The Milà family occupied the entire first floor, while the upper floors were split into smaller apartments and rented out. Gaudí did not use the colorful tiles and mosaics that characterize most of his work. Instead, he opted for an extraordinary biomorphic design: the stonework facades undulate like waves; the sculptural wrought-ironwork resembles plant forms; and the ceiling of the laundry area in the attic calls to mind the ribcage of a huge, whalelike creature.

Behind his flights of fancy, however, Gaudí's ideas served a practical purpose. The strange figures on the roof terrace actually conceal air vents and stairwells, while in the basement is Barcelona's first garage.